keep his balance. The puppy paused mid-stride on the veranda and started to bark and howl weirdly at Papaji, waking him from his slumber. Chimpu took a few steps towards him, growling his puppy growl, and fell, off-balance. Papaji helped a struggling Chimpu up. As soon as Chimpu was up again, he turned back and ran inside, swaying left and right. Papaji followed him. We stood near the kitchen as Chimpu ran past us, and, like an unguided missile, banged his head into the base of a long, thin flower vase. Before Papaji could reach for it, the vase hit the floor and shattered into pieces. 'Oh no!' Papaji muttered.

'What happened?' It was Maa's voice from inside the bedroom. She came out at once and stared at the scattered pieces of her favourite flower vase, surprised. A questioning stare swept from Papaji to the two of us. She carefully made her way through the broken pieces and found Chimpu lying with all fours up in the air near the broken base of the vase, all four paws in the air, continuously in motion, as if running. Papaji bent forward and lifted Chimpu in his arms, raised him closer to his face and sniffed. Chimpu was now almost unconscious. The twitching of Papaji's facial muscles signalled that something was wrong. Maa found the hand towel and the opened bottle, the evidence of something that now appeared to be a crime. Dada and I stood silent, trying to appear innocent. 'What did you two do?' Maa asked Dada very calmly. At first, Dada didn't say a word, terrified from the moment the vase had broken. But then Maa consoled him, 'It's okay, beta, don't worry about the vase. I just want to know what happened. Or Chimpu will be hurt. You do not want that to happen, right?' Slowly, Dada told them about the whole incident.

'So you're saying it was Gunju's idea?' Maa said as Dada nodded. She then looked at Papaji, who was smiling. 'She used your rum-massage formula! She's your typical *fauji* kid,' Maa concluded, and then, after a moment of pause, both of them burst into uncontrollable laughter. 'We have to teach our curious kid that rum is not the solution to all problems,' Papaji said as he laughed. Dada and I kept looking at each other, still. Chimpu barked twice and fell unconscious again, only to wake up after five long hours of deep slumber.